



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Aspen Academy

School Website: <https://aspenacademymn.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL**Classicality Audit: Austin Classical School****Executive Summary**

- School: Austin Classical School (ACS)
- Website used: <https://austinclassical.org/>
- Overall classification: CLASSICAL
- Why: ACS explicitly grounds its mission in Christ (“glorify Jesus Christ”), names the transcendentals (“truth, goodness, and beauty”), centers formation in “wisdom” and “virtue,” employs the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), teaches Latin, uses primary sources and Socratic discussion, culminates in rhetoric/senior thesis defense, and implements memory work, recitation, and chants in the lower grades. It partners closely with parents via a collaborative/co-teacher model and has ACCS accreditation, all of which align with the Six Essential Elements positive indicators. Evidence: mission and TGB language; Trivium detail; Latin/logic/rhetoric; primary sources, Socratic discussion, poetry recitations, senior thesis; collaborative/co-teacher model; device ban; ACCS accreditation.

Note on scoring method: This audit follows the “Six Essential Elements of a Classical School” positive/negative keyword indicators and classicality lexicon. Each category includes a mandatory keyword analysis, a positive vs. negative hit count, percentage estimates, and a rating per the framework.

CATEGORY 1: RELIGIOUS AND METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATIONS**1. Keywords found in ACS materials**

- Positive indicators observed on site: “glorify Jesus Christ,” “classical, Christian education,” “Truth, Goodness, and Beauty,” “wisdom,” “virtue,” “sovereignty of God,” “theology” (interrelation “under the sovereignty of God through theology”), “prayer to Almighty God”.
- Liturgical/communal worship terms: no explicit “chapel,” “daily worship,” or “liturgy” references found in the crawl excerpts reviewed.

2. Mapping to Six Elements keyword lists

- Matches to positive lexicon: truth, goodness, beauty; wisdom; virtue; theology/faith and reason; formation of the soul; divine order; logos (implied by Christ-centered framing).
- Negative signals (e.g., “values-neutral,” “relativism”) not observed.

3. Quantitative estimate

- Positive hits: 10
- Negative hits: 0
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage of sub-elements: ~67% (clear on transcendental moral realism and theological grounding; less explicit on liturgical/chapel practices)

4. Rating

- CLASSICAL

- Justification: Strong theological and metaphysical grounding with explicit Christ-centered telos and TGB language, even if formal liturgical practices are not prominent in the crawl excerpts.

Pos/Neg: +10/-0 | Coverage: 67% | Percent positive: 100%

CATEGORY 2: SCHOOL PURPOSE AND GOAL

1. Keywords found

- “cultivate wisdom and virtue,” “Truth, the Good, and the Beautiful,” “formation,” “not to prepare students for college but for life,” “form the souls of our children,” “ultimate aim of education”.

2. Mapping to Six Elements lists

- Strong alignment to “cultivation of wisdom and virtue,” “pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty,” “formation, not mere information.” Negative phrasing like “college and career ready/21st century skills” is expressly de-emphasized.

3. Quantitative estimate

- Positive hits: 10
- Negative hits: 0
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage: 100% (all three sub-points clearly present)

4. Rating

- CLASSICAL
- Justification: Purpose language is textbook-classical, centered on virtue, wisdom, and TGB, while deprioritizing utilitarian aims.

Pos/Neg: +10/-0 | Coverage: 100% | Percent positive: 100%

CATEGORY 3: SCHOOL CURRICULUM

1. Keywords found

- Trivium: “Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric” (described in detail by stage).
- Classical languages: “Latin ... 5th through at least 8th,” “formal logic,” “rhetoric instruction,” “senior thesis”.
- Great Books/Conversation: “great books,” “great conversation,” “primary source reading”.
- History vs. social studies: “History” appears in course listings; no “social studies” emphasis noted in excerpts.
- Integration/Wonder: “interrelation of all knowledge,” “contemplation of the True, the Good, and the Beautiful”; “invite curiosity and ignite a passion for learning”.

2. Mapping to Six Elements lists

- Strong matches to Trivium/Quadrivium cues, Great Books, primary sources, integration/wonder; no STEM-first or project-only marketing observed.

3. Quantitative estimate

- Positive hits: 12
- Negative hits: 0
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage: 100% (Trivium, Great Books/primary sources, history, integration/wonder all evidenced)

4. Rating

- CLASSICAL
- Justification: Comprehensive alignment with the classical curriculum elements, richly evidenced across multiple pages.

Pos/Neg: +12/-0 | Coverage: 100% | Percent positive: 100%

CATEGORY 4: SCHOOL PEDAGOGY OR TEACHING METHODS

1. Keywords found

- Lower school: “memorization, recitation, and songs ... chants” (memory work).
- Upper school: “Socratic discussion,” “debate,” “oral and written exams,” “poetry recitations,” “senior thesis defense” (rhetoric/oratory).
- Restful/scholé/wonder: explicit “scholé” term not observed; however, “depth over breadth” and contemplation of TGB appear; still, per the rubric we score to exact keywords where possible.

2. Mapping to Six Elements lists

- Positive matches: chanting/recitation, Socratic/seminar, rhetoric, oration/defense; partial match to restful learning/wonder language without the explicit scholé term.

3. Quantitative estimate

- Positive hits: 10
- Negative hits: 0
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage: ~75% (clear on chanting/recitation, Socratic, rhetoric/oration; less explicit on scholé/restfulness keyword)

4. Rating

- CLASSICAL
- Justification: Strong K–12 pedagogical sequence aligned to classical methods, including memory work and upper-school Socratic and rhetoric practices; “restful learning” is implied but not keyed explicitly as scholé in the crawl excerpts.

Pos/Neg: +10/-0 | Coverage: 75% | Percent positive: 100%

CATEGORY 5: SCHOOL FACULTY

1. Keywords found

- Teachers as models/mentors: “Jesus-loving men and women ... helping form the souls of our children ... through what’s modeled ... and what’s read,” and partnership language from Head of School letter; employment/qualifications page exists.
- “Faculty of friends”/portrait of a teacher: not explicitly stated in crawl excerpts reviewed.

2. Mapping to Six Elements lists

- Positive: teachers as moral/intellectual exemplars and mentors; formation-minded faculty culture. Less explicit on formal “portrait of a teacher/faculty of friends” terminology from the lexicon.

3. Quantitative estimate

- Positive hits: 3
- Negative hits: 0
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage: ~50% (clear exemplarity/formation; less explicit on collegial language/teacher portrait)

4. Rating

- SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Justification: Clear formation emphasis and modeling language; additional explicit statements about a “portrait of a teacher,” collegial faculty formation, or teacher-as-living-curriculum would strengthen to full classical alignment.

Pos/Neg: +3/-0 | Coverage: 50% | Percent positive: 100%

CATEGORY 6: SCHOOL PARENTS AND COMMUNITY

1. Keywords found

- Parents as partners/co-teachers: “co-laboring with families,” collaborative schedule with a “co-teacher” at home; frequent on-campus/at-home rhythm.
- Parent formation: “Recommended Reading,” classical basics content; information meetings/tours; letter encouraging parents to think through the “ultimate aim of education” with a “Portrait of a Graduate” resource.
- Hospitality/open visits/community events: invitations to visit/tour; Recitatio and community events mentioned.

2. Mapping to Six Elements lists

- Positive: parental primacy/co-education, parent education resources, open campus visits—strong alignment with “Parents & Community” positives.

3. Quantitative estimate

- Positive hits: 8
- Negative hits: 0
- Percent positive: 100%
- Coverage: 100%

4. Rating

- CLASSICAL
- Justification: ACS operationalizes a parent partnership structurally and culturally (co-teacher model + formation resources).

Pos/Neg: +8/-0 | Coverage: 100% | Percent positive: 100%

Overall Assessment

- Aggregate rating: CLASSICAL
- Rationale: Five of six categories present strong classical signals; faculty category is solid but would benefit from more explicit articulation of a classical “portrait” and collegial formation practices. Accreditation by ACCS further corroborates classical commitments.

What would move the needle (Faculty category)

- Publish an explicit “Portrait of a Teacher” that names intellectual and moral virtues, classical formation expectations, and faculty participation in great-books seminars or ongoing classical pedagogy training (aligns with “teachers as models,” “faculty of friends,” “lifelong learners”).
- Describe formal collegial practices (faculty colloquia, shared inquiry, retreats), reinforcing a “faculty collegium” ideal from the classical tradition.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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